



This illustration from the *Vallard Atlas* of 1547 depicts Jacques Cartier and members of the abortive French-Canadian colony of 1541–42.

“ I AM INCLINED TO BELIEVE THAT **THIS IS THE LAND GOD GAVE TO CAIN.** ”

Jacques Cartier, French explorer, about Canada, 1536

THE BATTLE OF PREVEZA, fought off western Greece in September 1538, further underlined the reach of Ottoman naval power. It pitched the Ottomans against a combined Papal, Venetian, Genoese, and Spanish fleet brought together by Pope Paul III. The **Ottoman victory** highlighted the difficulty the Christians faced in welding together disparate, uneasily allied forces.

In August 1539, **Ghent**, the birthplace of Charles V, **rose in revolt** against him. The issue was tax, demanded by Charles to finance his Italian wars. It revealed the difficulties faced by Charles V in imposing authority over autonomous cities determined to guard their “liberties” by refusing to pay a distant ruler for an equally distant campaign. Charles personally oversaw the

suppression of the revolt and the city’s notables were forced to parade barefoot. The underlying tension, however, remained.

Despite concerted efforts, the **Spanish exploration of North America** in the 16th century proved discouraging. The myths that drove it—a waterway linking the Atlantic and Pacific, the “Seven Cities of Gold”—proved to be just that. The reality was vast territories that proved hostile and unrewarding. Nonetheless, from 1539, **Hernando de Soto** led a four-year expedition across much of the southern territories of today’s US. Similarly, in 1540–42, **Francisco Vázquez de Coronado** headed a still larger force north from Mexico, penetrating as far as Kansas. And in 1542–43, **Juan Rodríguez Cabrillo** led a fleet north along the unknown Pacific coast, discovering San Diego harbor. But none of these ventures would be followed up until the end of the century.

French attempts at settlement in North America, promoted in part

Battle of Préveza
Despite the size of the Christian fleet at the Battle of Préveza in September 1538, it proved no match for the Ottoman fleet led by Khair ed-Din (Barbarossa).

by nervousness of being beaten to it by Spain (just as Spain was anxious not to be outflanked by France), proved no more fruitful. Initial efforts had been made in 1534 and then in 1535–36 by **Jacques Cartier** (1491–1557), in the course of which the Gulf of St. Lawrence and then the St. Lawrence River in present-day **Canada** were reached and claimed for France. In 1541, by now thoroughly alarmed by Spanish intentions, France launched a more substantial expedition to Canada with the explicit goal of establishing a permanent settlement. It was led by Jean-François de la Rocque de Roberval, with Cartier his deputy, and was a dismal failure. Cartier returned, unauthorized, to France in 1542 with “gold and diamonds” that proved worthless. Roberval abandoned the colony the following year after a winter of near starvation. French efforts in North America would not be renewed for half a century.

A consequence of the Catholic response to the Reformation was the missionary work undertaken between 1541 and 1552 by **Francis Xavier** (1506–52), a cofounder of the **Jesuits** in 1534. Conceived on a heroic scale, its aim was to spread Christianity to East Asia. Xavier traveled via Mozambique to Goa, then to the Spice Islands between 1545 and 1547, and then to Canton and Japan before returning to China, where he died in 1552. His Christian conversions are said to have been exceeded only by St. Paul.



THE FIRST CONTACT BETWEEN EUROPE AND JAPAN WAS IN 1543.

According to the Portuguese writer and explorer **Fernão Mendes Pinto**, it occurred on the island of Tanegashima, to the south of the main Japanese archipelago. Not only did the Portuguese introduce firearms to Japan, but they became intermediaries between China and Japan, whose merchants had been forbidden to trade with the Chinese as a result of persistent raids by Japanese pirates.

In 1543, the Polish mathematician **Nicolaus Copernicus** (1473–1543) published *On the Revolution of the Heavenly Bodies*. It was based not on Copernicus’s own observations of the heavens so much as on those of Greek and Arab astronomers. Nonetheless, he was able to demonstrate that these much older observations were more readily explained by the **Earth orbiting the Sun** rather



Copernicus's Universe

This painting by Andreas Cellarius from 1660 shows “The system of the entire created Universe according to Copernicus.”

